

Strategic Modeling — Module 06: Learning —

Discussion Questions

20 questions on adaptive strategy, dynamic capabilities, and strategic experimentation.

1. Why does Teece argue that dynamic capabilities (sensing, seizing, transforming) are more important than static competitive positions?
2. Google maintains a portfolio of strategic experiments, killing those that fail. How does this approach generate strategic learning?
3. How does the speed of the competitive learning loop determine competitive advantage?
4. When is "unlearning" a successful strategy necessary? Give an example of an organization that failed to unlearn.
5. Compare strategic experimentation with traditional R&D. What's different about experimenting with strategy versus technology?
6. How do "fail fast" cultures actually generate faster strategic learning? What makes them work?
7. When should a firm double down on its current strategic model versus exploring alternatives?
8. How do venture capital and corporate venture arms serve as strategic learning vehicles?
9. What makes some organizations better at adaptive strategy than others?
10. How does organizational inertia slow the competitive learning loop?
11. Design a "strategic experiment" to test one uncertain assumption in your organization's strategy.
12. Compare the competitive learning loops of two firms in the same industry. Which learns faster? What structural differences explain the gap?
13. Map your organization's dynamic capabilities: sensing (how well?), seizing (how fast?), transforming (how deeply?).
14. Identify a strategy your organization needs to unlearn. What makes unlearning so difficult in this case?
15. Design an innovation portfolio with explicit learning objectives for each experiment.

16. How should the balance between exploitation and exploration change as an industry matures?
17. What metrics would tell you whether your organization is learning from its strategic experiments?
18. Compare "probe and learn" with "bet big and execute" as strategic approaches. When is each appropriate?
19. How do absorptive capacity and open innovation accelerate strategic learning?
20. When is it smarter to copy a competitor's successful strategy (imitative learning) rather than innovate?